

Poetry + TPCASTT

How to analyze poetry

Example poem:

Nothing Gold Can Stay

Robert Frost - 1874-1963

Nature's first green is gold,
Her hardest hue to hold.
Her early leaf's a flower;
But only so an hour.
Then leaf subsides to leaf.
So Eden sank to grief,
So dawn goes down to day.
Nothing gold can stay.

Why Is Poetry So Hard?

Poetry can be difficult because poets often:

- Use figurative language
- Leave things unstated
- Use unusual word choices
- Organize ideas in unexpected ways
- Create multiple possible meanings

The problem: "I don't understand this poem."

The solution: Slow down and analyze it step-by-step.

Parts of a Poem

Line: A single row of words in a poem.

- Poetry is organized into lines, rather than sentences across a page.

Stanza: A group of lines separated from other groups by a space.

- Think of it like a paragraph in poetry.

Rhyme: Words that have similar ending sounds.

- light / night | stay / day

Rhyme Scheme: The pattern of rhyme at the ends of lines.

- Use letters:
 - The cat sat on the mat. → A
 - It looked up at the sky. → B
 - It chased a little bat. → A
 - Then watched the bird fly by. → B

Rhyme Scheme: ABAB

Poetic Structure

Enjambment: When a sentence or thought continues from one line into the next without punctuation at the end of the line.

- For example:
 - I walked into the room and saw
 - the sunlight shining through the window.
- The thought continues across the line break.

End-Stopped Line: A line that ends with punctuation.

- For example:
 - The sun disappeared.
 - The moon came out.
 - The animals revered.

What Is TPCASTT?

TPCASTT is a strategy that helps us break a poem into manageable pieces.

Letter	Step
T	Title
P	Paraphrase
C	Connotation
A	Attitude
S	Shifts
T	Title 2
T	Theme

TPCASTT is a process, not a formula.

You aren't trying to find the "one correct answer."

You are building an interpretation using **evidence from the poem.**

T: Title (Before Reading)

Before you read the poem, look at the title.

Ask:

- What does the title literally mean?
- What does it make me expect?
- What could the poem be about?
- Does the title suggest a person, place, object, idea, or event?

Students often forget about the title, but it is just as important as the lines of poetry. Sometimes it gives us the most important context you don't get in the poem itself!

Make a prediction: Before reading, I predict this poem will be about _____ because _____.

Don't worry about being right yet.

Example: Predicting from a Title

Title: "Nothing Gold Can Stay"

Before reading, you might predict:

Before reading the poem, I predict that "gold" represents something valuable or beautiful that does not last forever.

Notice: You're not analyzing the entire poem yet. You're simply asking: "What does this title make me think?"

Write a Title TPCASTT in the margins of your handout

Before reading, I predict this poem will be about _____ because _____.

P: Paraphrase

Paraphrase = Put the poem into your own words.

Think: What is literally happening?

Do NOT worry about the deeper meaning yet.

Ask:

- Who is speaking?
- What is happening?
- What is the speaker describing?
- What happens first?
- What happens next?

Think:

“What does this poem say?”

Paraphrase ≠ Summary

Summary: A shortened version of the text.

Paraphrase: The poem's ideas rewritten in your own words, often line-by-line or section-by-section.

Example:

Poetic language: "The moonlight danced across the water."

Paraphrase: Moonlight reflected and moved across the surface of the water.

Don't analyze yet! You're not explaining that the moon represents hope, just that it is being described as moving.

Practice

Nothing Gold Can Stay

Robert Frost - 1874-1963

Nature's first green is gold,
Her hardest hue to hold.
Her early leaf's a flower;
But only so an hour.
Then leaf subsides to leaf.
So Eden sank to grief,
So dawn goes down to day.
Nothing gold can stay.

Read through *Nothing Gold Can Stay*. Write a Paraphrase TPCASTT in the margins of your handout

Suggestion: for a poem this short, do line by line. For longer poems, do line by line or stanza by stanza.

Wheeler PARA

Nothing Gold Can Stay

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Paraphrase:

The first leaves of spring are as beautiful as flowers, but that beauty only lasts for a short time. Eventually, the special early leaves become ordinary leaves. Frost compares this loss to the biblical Garden of Eden losing its perfection. Morning eventually becomes ordinary daytime, just as beautiful moments eventually change.

Overall:

Beautiful and special things in life do not last forever.

C: Connotation

Now we move beyond:

“What does the poem say?” to “What does the poem suggest?”

Connotation = The feelings, ideas, associations, or meanings connected to a word.

Words can have:

- Denotation → literal meaning
- Connotation → feelings/associations

Denotation vs. Connotation

HOME

Denotation:

The place where someone lives.

Possible connotations:

- Safety
- Family
- Comfort
- Belonging
- Childhood

Word: House

Denotation:

A building where someone lives.

Possible connotations:

- Structure
- Property
- Shelter
- Physical space

Same basic idea ≠ same feeling. **Poets choose words carefully.**

What Should I Look For?

During Connotation, look for:

- Diction: important word choices
- Figurative language: metaphor, simile, personification, allusion, etc.
- Imagery: sensory details
- Symbols: objects/ideas that represent something more
- Sound: repetition, rhyme, alliteration, etc.

Ask: Why did the poet choose these particular words?

Write a Connotation TPCASTT in the margins of your handout. Circle moments of diction/figurative language/imagery/symbols/or sound then explain the connotation of them.

Wheeler CONN

Nothing Gold Can Stay

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Gold:

- Symbol of value/beauty/rarity/wealth/precious
- So when Frost calls nature's first green "gold," he isn't simply talking about a color. He makes the moment seem precious and valuable.

Personification:

- Nature is personified as a her. It makes the beauty of nature more relatable & emotional.

Allusion:

- Eden = the Garden of Eden. Eden represents beauty/innocence/perfection, but it falls & the beauty is lost. The early leaves & Eden represent something perfect that can't remain forever.

Symbolism:

- Dawn symbolizes new beginnings, hope, innocence, & birth, but eventually turns into regular day.

A: Attitude

Attitude = The speaker's feelings toward the subject.

Think:

How does the speaker feel?

Possible attitudes:

- Happy / Angry / Hopeful / Bitter / Nostalgic / Frustrated / Lonely / Peaceful / Fearful / Confused / Proud / Regretful / Sarcastic

Important: The speaker is NOT automatically the poet.

How Do We Know the Attitude?

Don't just say: "The speaker is sad."

Ask: What evidence makes you think that?

Look at: Word choice + imagery + figurative language + punctuation + sound

Formula: The speaker's attitude is _____ because the poet uses _____ to show _____.

Write an Attitude TPCASTT in the margins of your handout. You can use the formula

Wheeler ATTITUDE

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The speaker's attitude seems reflective and somewhat melancholy about the fact that beautiful things do not last because the poem uses sorrowful words such as "grief" and words that represent a change from beauty into the ordinary.

Tone vs. Attitude

You may hear the word tone instead of attitude.

For our purposes: Attitude / Tone = The speaker's emotional perspective toward the subject.

Example: "Great. Another Monday."

The words themselves don't directly say: "I am annoyed."

But the attitude is probably: annoyed / frustrated / sarcastic

S: Shifts

Poems don't always stay emotionally or conceptually the same.

A shift is a change in:

- Mood
- Attitude
- Speaker's thinking
- Setting
- Time
- Perspective
- Topic
- Tone

Ask: does something change?

How Can I Find a Shift?

Look for signal words:

- but
- yet
- however
- although
- then
- instead
- still
- now
- finally

Also look for:

- A new stanza
- A change in punctuation
- A change in imagery
- A change from past → present
- A change from positive → negative
- A realization by the speaker

Write a Shift TPCASTT in the margins of your handout. Mark the shift! Put a ★ next to the line where you think the change happens.

Wheeler SHIFT

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Nothing gold can stay.

This one is more obvious because we have a "BUT." Other poems will not have as obvious of a shift.

The poem moves from describing the beauty of nature to emphasizing its temporary nature.

T: Revisit the Title

Now that you've read and analyzed the poem, return to the title.

Ask: Does the title mean something different now?

Before reading: What did I think the title meant?

After reading: What does the title actually suggest?

This is where the title can become symbolic or meaningful in a new way.

Now that you have worked through the entire poem, write a Title2
TPCASTT in the margins of your handout.

Wheeler TITLE REVISIT

Before reading:

We thought: "Gold" = something beautiful or valuable.

After reading: We have more evidence.

Gold can represent:

- Beauty/Youth/Innocence/Perfection/Happiness/Special moments/New beginnings

"Nothing gold can stay" now means more than: "Gold doesn't last."

It suggests: **Beautiful or perfect moments in life are temporary.**

T: Theme

Theme = The larger message or idea about life that the poem communicates.

Theme is NOT:

- A one-word topic
- A summary
- "The poem is about love."

Instead: What does the poem say about love?

Theme is explaining the larger message written in statement format.

Topic vs. Theme

TOPIC: Friendship

THEME: True friendship requires people to support each other during difficult times.

TOPIC: Choices

THEME: The choices people make can shape how they understand their lives.

Write a Theme Statement TPCASTT in the margins of your handout. It may benefit you to figure out the topic first, then change it into a theme statement of what does this poem say about the topic.

Wheeler THEME

TOPIC: Change

What is Frost saying about change?

- Beautiful things don't last forever.
- Everything eventually changes.
- Moments of perfection are temporary.
- People must accept that beauty and innocence cannot last forever.

STATEMENT: **Beautiful and perfect moments in life are temporary, making them valuable while they last.**

The Triangle ▲

Remember, just like the author is not always the main character in the book, the poet is not always the speaker. There are 3 different types of people* within a poem: Speaker, Subject, & Addressee.

*they don't have to be a person, they could be people, animals, entities, objects, ideas, whatever!

Speaker

Speaker (The Voice): The persona or character who "talks" in the poem.

The speaker is not automatically the real-life author or poet; it can be an imagined person, an animal, an object, or a historical figure

*The Speaker ≠ The Poet

- The speaker is the voice of the poem, like a narrator in fiction.
- Poets often create personas or adopt perspectives very different from their own.
- Ask yourself:
 - Who is speaking?
 - What do we know (age, gender, situation, emotions, relationships)?
 - What motivates them to speak?
- The poem's tone, diction, and details can help you infer the speaker's attitude and context.

Subject

Subject (The Topic): The core idea, event, object, or feeling that the poem is about. It answers the question, "What is the poem focusing on?"

****Finding the Subject**

- The subject is what the poem is about on the surface aka the situation or event.
- Ask:
 - What is literally happening?
 - What is the poem responding to (a memory, death, love, injustice, etc.)?
 - Identifying the subject helps ground your analysis before you dive into deeper interpretation.

Audience

Audience: The person, group, object, or abstract idea that the speaker talks to. Even if a poem feels private, it implies a reader or listener. The addressee is often revealed through pronouns like "you". Sometimes you have to assume the audience based on the context. You must ask: Who is the target listener, and how does the speaker expect them to react?

***Finding the Audience

- The audience is the person, object, or idea the speaker is addressing (real or imagined)
- Ask:
 - Who is the speaker talking to (directly or indirectly)?
 - What's their relationship? (Lover, God, self, society, reader?)
 - How does that audience shape the tone or purpose of the poem?
- *Tip: Sometimes the addressee is unclear or symbolic and that ambiguity adds complexity to your interpretation.*

Find the triangle

Identify the triangle in the margins

Speaker: who is speaking?



Subject: what is the poem about?

Audience: who is the poem talking to?

Wheeler TRIANGLE

Speaker	An observant, reflective speaker	The speaker is someone observing the changes in nature and reflecting on how quickly beauty and perfection disappear. We don't need to assume the speaker is Robert Frost himself.
Subject	The temporary nature of beauty, perfection, and new beginnings	On the surface, the poem describes nature changing from its beautiful early spring state into something ordinary. More deeply, it considers how nothing beautiful or perfect lasts forever.
Audience	The reader / anyone reflecting on change and impermanence	There isn't a clearly identified person being addressed. The poem is presented as a reflection for the reader to consider.

Analysis Notes Framework

TPCASTT + Triangle

Title: Make a prediction about what the poem might be about by considering its title.

Paraphrase: Translate the poem line by line into your own words, focusing on the literal meaning of the text.

Connotation: Look for figurative language, imagery, and other poetic devices that add layers of meaning beyond the literal.

Attitude/Tone: Identify the speaker's attitude toward the subject matter and the overall tone of the poem.

Shift: Find any dramatic transformations in the speaker's point of view, looking for key words, punctuation, or stanza changes that signal a shift in meaning.

Analysis Notes Framework (in margins)

Title (Revisited): Re-examine the title, now with your deeper understanding of the poem, and consider its interpretive significance.

Theme: State the central message or idea of the poem in a complete sentence, summarizing what the poet is trying to say about the human experience.

▲ – Speaker, subject, audience

Having a standard analysis framework allows you to tackle whatever prompt you are given for analysis. This format covers all of the bases. When presented with a poem, track these in the margins/on scrap paper/in your journal.